Fall Protection Inspection Checklist (OSHA 29 CFR 1926.501)

Use when a work area at height is set up, after any change to edges, openings or roof work, and on routine site walks.

OSHA 29 CFR 1926.501

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A; use N/A only when that work or condition is not on site.
2. For each Defect, keep workers away from the exposure until it is corrected, then record the fix, who made it and the date.
3. The manufacturer's instructions for each system and your site rules may add checks; 1926.502 sets the criteria the systems must meet.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1926.501: Duty to have fall protection (Part 1926, Subpart M: Fall Protection) System criteria: 29 CFR 1926.502 Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09

Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1926-501-duty-have-fall-protection

SECTION A | Surfaces, edges and openings

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Surface strength Ref. 1926.501(a)(2)	The employer has determined the surface can support employees safely; nobody works on a surface not yet confirmed as strong enough.	☐	☐	☐	
2	Systems meet 1926.502 Ref. 1926.501(a)(1)	Guardrails, nets and arrest equipment on site match the 1926.502 criteria for that type of system.	☐	☐	☐	
3	Open sides and edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(1)	Every side or edge with a drop of 6 ft or more has a guardrail or safety net, or each exposed worker uses a PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	
4	Hoist areas Ref. 1926.501(b)(3)	Guardrail or PFAS where workers could fall at least 6 ft; anyone leaning through an opening with the guardrail, chain or gate removed is protected by a PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	
5	Ramps, runways and walkways Ref. 1926.501(b)(6)	Guardrail systems along each ramp, runway or walkway where the fall to the level below is at least 6 ft.	☐	☐	☐	
6	Wall openings Ref. 1926.501(b)(14)	Openings whose outside bottom edge is 6 ft or higher above lower levels and whose inside bottom edge is under 39 in above the working surface are guarded by guardrail, net or PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	
7	Other elevated surfaces Ref. 1926.501(b)(15)	Any surface 6 ft or higher not covered by another item has a guardrail, net or PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION B | Holes, excavations and dangerous equipment

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
8	Holes and skylights over 6 ft Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(i)	Each hole or skylight more than 6 ft above a lower level is covered or guardrailed, or workers near it use a PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Holes, excavations and dangerous equipment						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
9	Trip and step-through covers Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(ii)	Covers are in place over holes and skylights where workers could trip in or step into or through them.	☐	☐	☐	
10	Covers against falling objects Ref. 1926.501(b)(4)(iii)	Covers stop objects falling through holes and skylights onto workers.	☐	☐	☐	
11	Hidden excavation edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(7)(i)	Excavations 6 ft deep or more that are hidden by plant growth or another visual barrier have guardrails, fences or barricades at the edge.	☐	☐	☐	
12	Wells, pits and shafts Ref. 1926.501(b)(7)(ii)	Wells, pits, shafts and similar excavations 6 ft or deeper have guardrails, fences, barricades or covers.	☐	☐	☐	
13	Dangerous equipment below 6 ft Ref. 1926.501(b)(8)(i)	Workers less than 6 ft above dangerous equipment are kept from falling into or onto it by guardrails or equipment guards.	☐	☐	☐	
14	Dangerous equipment at 6 ft or more Ref. 1926.501(b)(8)(ii)	Workers 6 ft or more above dangerous equipment are protected by guardrails, a PFAS or safety nets.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Roofs, leading edges and specific trades						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
15	Low-slope roof edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(10)	Roofers have guardrails, nets, a PFAS, or a warning line system combined with a guardrail, net, PFAS or safety monitor.	☐	☐	☐	
16	Safety monitor used alone Ref. 1926.501(b)(10)	A safety monitor working without warning lines is used only on low-slope roofs 50 ft (15.25 m) wide or less.	☐	☐	☐	
17	Steep roof edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(11)	Guardrail systems with toeboards, safety nets or PFAS protect everyone on the steep roof.	☐	☐	☐	
18	Leading edge work Ref. 1926.501(b)(2)(i)	Workers building a leading edge use guardrails, nets or a PFAS, or a 1926.502(k) fall protection plan is in place and followed after the employer has shown those systems are infeasible or more hazardous.	☐	☐	☐	
19	Others near leading edges Ref. 1926.501(b)(2)(ii)	Workers on a surface where leading edges are being built, but not doing that work, have PFAS, nets or guardrails; a control line replaces the guardrail along the edge parallel to the leading edge only where the leading edge crew already works inside its own controlled access zone.	☐	☐	☐	
20	Precast concrete erection Ref. 1926.501(b)(12)	Workers erecting or grouting precast members have guardrails, nets or PFAS, or the 1926.502(k) plan exception applies.	☐	☐	☐	
21	Residential construction Ref. 1926.501(b)(13)	Residential crews working at height have guardrails, a safety net or a PFAS, an alternative allowed by another paragraph (b) provision, or a 1926.502(k) plan where the employer has demonstrated infeasibility or a greater hazard.	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION C | Roofs, leading edges and specific trades

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
22	Formwork and rebar Ref. 1926.501(b)(5)	Workers on the face of formwork or reinforcing steel use a PFAS, safety net or positioning device system.	☐	☐	☐	
23	Overhand bricklaying Ref. 1926.501(b)(9)(i)	Bricklayers have a PFAS, guardrails or a safety net, or work within the controlled access zone.	☐	☐	☐	
24	Reaching below the work surface Ref. 1926.501(b)(9)(ii)	Anyone reaching more than 10 in (25 cm) below the surface they stand on is protected by a guardrail system, a net or a PFAS.	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Falling objects

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
25	Hard hats Ref. 1926.501(c)	Every worker in a falling-object zone wears a hard hat, and at least one of items D2 to D4 is in place.	☐	☐	☐	
26	Toeboards, screens or guardrails Ref. 1926.501(c)(1)	If used, toeboards, screens or guardrails stop objects dropping from the levels above.	☐	☐	☐	
27	Canopy Ref. 1926.501(c)(2)	If chosen, a canopy covers the work area below and loose material is kept back from the upper edge so it cannot go over if knocked.	☐	☐	☐	
28	Barricaded drop zone Ref. 1926.501(c)(3)	Alternatively, the area where objects could land is barricaded, entry is prohibited, and material is stored back from the edge so it cannot go over if displaced.	☐	☐	☐	

DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE? ☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE	DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW	DATE / TIME